From Review to Remediation: Building a Sustainable Reparative Metadata Workflow



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HW

Hello! Welcome to our session READ SLIDE TITLE today at NLA MPLA. We appreciate you coming to learn about our work at UNL Libraries.

My name is Harriet Wintermute. I am the department chair for ACME which stands for Acquisitions, Cataloging, Metadata, and E-Resources at the University of Nebraska-Lincoln Libraries. Presenting with me today is Broghan White, Cataloging & Metadata Librarian. Our project team also included Meg Mering, Metadata Librarian.

Pilot

April 2025 to August 2026

Library of Congress Subject Headings:

- Illegal immigration
- Problem children
- Sexual minorities
- McKinley, Mount (Alaska)
- America, Gulf of



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- We undertook a pilot project
- Spent over a year on this project, starting in April 2025 and last headings completed in August 2026.
- Five LCSH terms were selected for the pilot:
  - READ EACH HEADING
- Taking related variants into account – we reviewed and addressed over 100 headings.
- Keep watching….we'll reveal the changes for these five terms.

Goal

Develop practices to replace or supplement pejorative or outdated terms in our metadata

Engage stakeholders early and often
Build sustainable, documented processes
Leverage native Alma and Primo tools
Apply changes consortium-wide
Design every change to be reversible



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- Project charge was to review, test and implement practices to replace or supplement pejorative or outdated terms in our metadata
- We approached this work intentionally
  - Included stakeholder communication and feedback channels
    - as often as possible,
    - and before moving forward with changes
  - The work needed to be sustainable, easily manageable, and documented for future use
  - Supporting that sustainability meant we wanted to use native tools already available to ExLibris Alma and Primo programmatically
  - We are in an Alma Network Zone environment and
    - we wanted to support our consortium members in the NU system (UNO UNK UNMC UNL Law)
    - by rolling out the changes in the network zone
      - Not just in our Institution Zone
    - Tat way most of the changes would benefit everyone with the least effort

- Lastly, another requirement towards sustainability
    - Any changes we would make needed to be reversible
    - The Library of Congress might update their headings to ones we wanted to use again soeday
    - Also language and preferences change over time, so even a currently respectful term might need upating in a few years.

Getting started

Other library work as inspiration

University of Toronto:
Indigenous Metadata Work

Washington Research Library Consortium:
Reparative Cataloging CoP



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- Not new work - library workers have challenged biased LCSH language for decades
  - Sanford Berman in 1971 published Prejudices and Antipathies
  - Other librarians in the literature pointed out problems, including gender, LGBTQ+ terminology, and more
  - National attention with the “Change the Subject” documentary spotlights
    - Student activism at Dartmouth, 2019 regarding the previous "Illegal aliens" LCSH
  - Subject Analysis Committee, under the ALA divisions ALCTS now CORE report on "Illegal aliens,"
  - Cataloging Lab's Problem LCSH list, a community source for replacement terms
  - Library of Congress now working on multi-year project to update “Indians” headings
- Two peer library projects we examined closely for inspiration
  - University of Toronto used two part approach

    - First -- "mask" certain LCSH with more appropriate terms in the public display, using display normalization rules
    - second -- add local subject headings using uncontrolled to bibliographic records automatically to improve indexing matches.
- WRLC uses blended approaches
    - Local Autority Records
    - Bibliographic normalization rules to enhance records
    - Normalization rules to enhance Community Zone Records with local metadata
    - Primo display normalization (similar to Toronto)
    - DEI Exclude Terms – DOUBLE CHECK THIS
- We learned a lot from WRLC
    - They are also a consortial network zone environment and
    - We were able to borrow

Trigger: EO 14172 (Jan 2025) renamed Denali and Gulf of Mexico; LC quickly proposed changes to ~22 LCSH

Problem: LCSH/LCNAF auto-update in the Alma CZ, so we needed local processes

Pilot ran April 2025 to August 2026 (originally planned for 4 months)

Simple headings first, complex headings (many records, subdivisions) later

Test in IZ first, then implement in the shared UNCL NZ

Result: nearly 100 LCSH reviewed, replaced, or supplemented

Preliminary research (WCRL and UToronto)

Goals: replace/supplement terms, ensure everything is reversable, document everything, establish repeatable workflow

Research

Ask…

What do people call themselves?
What's respectful?
What's current?
What do other libraries use?
Who should we ask?
Replace, supplement, or keep?

Find…

Testimonials
Affinity groups
Committee publications
Peer libraries
News and journal articles



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- We are all librarians and we love to research, right?
- Researched each term in the pilot because we wanted to identify terms that were neutral language, person-first, or current
    - Search for what people call themselves, what's respectful?
    - If the use case is in a specific field or discipline – what's current terminology?
    - Maybe some other libraries have adopted newer terms – check with them – they might've done the research already.
    - Is there a community we should contact?
    - Dos the term need to be replaced entirely? Should we supplement the records with a variant term? Does our research find that the term is not inherently offensive and fine to keep as is?
- We know how to identify the good / authoritative sources. These could be things like
    - The author/creator's own words (their own blog, webpage, biographical statement, primary sources)
    - A community group such as a campus staff affinity group

- Professional organization committee reports and related publications
- Newspaper articles and interviews, or professional journal literature

Recommend

Identify action to propose

- Replace
- Conditional
- Supplement
- Retain



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- Once we've learned as much as we can about the term and alternatives, we consider a recommended action
    - Replace: when we can do a direct one-to-one switch out the old term for the new one
    - Conditional – Sometimes there are certain contexts we would like to address – it's not a 1:1 scenario but certain conditions have to be true before changing the term
    - Supplement – In some cases it's apparent we need to keep both the old and new term present in the record to help people find the resources. A good example of this use case are the recent changes to federally designated geographic names - it is helpful to have the newer and less known name on the record at the same time as the common or long used name
    - Retain – Sometimes there are names we can leave alone. This might be based on their use in the field, or because it's the official name of an event.
- We keep a big Excel workbook to track all this information including the

- recommendations, rationales, and feedback.

Rationale examples 1 & 2

Although these terms refer to the broad group of people who enter or remain in a country without legal authorization, the use of "Illegal," "unauthorized," and "undocumented" imply different connotations and perspectives. Not all immigration starts out as illegal activity. UNL Libraries considers "Undocumented immigration" a more respectful and neutral term to use.

The Library of Congress decided to replace the pejorative "Illegal aliens" heading with a complex solution, two tandem headings, "Noncitizens" and "Illegal immigration." When the immigration heading is present on records with headings containing "Noncitizens" (or many related variations), UNL Libraries will change the heading to use "Undocumented immigrants" instead.

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- With research and recommended action completed, we then prepare a rationale to provide an explanation and foundation
    - Reinforces that we are not making these decisions arbitrarily
    - That we have arrived at this decision with care and intention
- We aimed to provide a simple, succinct statement of the facts
    - using neutral language,
    - Centering the person – when applicable
    - Reflecting current usage
    - And grounded our reasons with citations
- There were times we also had to acknowledge tension and complexity (e.g., place names)
- We included these rationales in our tracking workbook and in much of our communication
- Here we have two example rationales we prepared related to the LCSH “Illegal Immigration”

- The first one applies when the term appears on the record on its own – i.e., is not accompanied by the LCSH “Noncitizens”
    - READ FIRST RATIONALE (in case someone cannot see it)
- The second rationale applies when the LCSH “illegal immigration” is accompanied by the LCSH “Noncitizens”
    - Here we have contextual implications – in many other cases, “Noncitizens” itself has nothing inherently bad, but in this specific scenario we wanted to update the term in the records.
    - READ SECOND RATIONALE

Rationale example 3

Library of Congress and the US Geological Survey (USGS) changed this term due to the signing of Executive Order 14172. As a US institution, it serves our users for our records to be consistent with the geographic names used by government agencies. However, there is an opportunity for confusion and a chance that resources become less discoverable for users who are unaware of the name change or its impact to LCSH. There has also been tension in both public and library discourse surrounding the reasons for the name change and the cultural impacts of the change. UNL Libraries will supplement records with both names.

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- And here's a third rationale we prepared, related to the geographic place names in our pilot --
  - McKinley, Mount (Alaska) …. Denali, Mount (Alaska)
  - America, Gulf of …. Mexico, Gulf of
- READ SLIDE (in case someone cannot see it)
- Here, due to the complexity and tension between federally designated name and cultural or common use, we decided to supplement, our records with the previous term, not replace them.

Stakeholders

We asked before we changed

Shared every proposal before implementation
Engaged Libraries staff, groups, and consortium members
Consulted communities and subject experts
Adapted when feedback called for it



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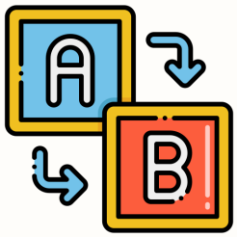
- We reached out to various stakeholder groups for their feedback on our proposed change
- Audiences:
  - Libraries faculty and staff (posts in our internal newsletter called Daily Buzz)
  - Libraries groups related to metadata, Alma, inclusive excellence….
  - Consortium group related to cataloging
- Shared information about the headings and proposed change, along with rationale and resources
- Gave about two weeks for feedback, with a reminder post
- Targeted outreach when needed:
  - Community: UNL Pride Affinity Group (Sexual minorities)
  - Subject expert: educational psychology faculty (Problem children)
  - Peers: BTAA libraries, UToronto, BTAA Heads of Cataloging meeting
- Feedback was largely supportive, and it changed outcomes
  - "Children with behavioral issues" became "problems," for parity with other thesauri [remove if already covered elsewhere]

- The place names round drew the most responses!

Making the change

At this point:

- ✓ Identified term needing reparative work
- ✓ Chose replacement/supplemental term
- ✓ Determined an action (replace, supplement, etc.)
- ✓ Gathered feedback from stakeholders



Choose the technical approach that best suits the desired action. Every approach is easily reversible!

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BW

To help track the steps of the workflow, here is a checklist of the pre-technical work steps

- identified a term that needs reparative work
- research to see what terminology other groups are using, like other libraries, researchers, and communities related to that term
- chosen a potential replacement or supplemental term and written a rationale to support
- determined the action we would like to take in repairing the term (replace, supplement, conditional)
- Gathered and addressed feedback from all stakeholders and affected communities

Questions remains: how do we do that
Rest of presentation: Tools and strategies for making the changes in our catalog and UNCL catalog

2 Alma environments: one for institutional changes and one for consortium-wide

changes – work done in both
Technical approach determined by our desired action

- Some tools are felxible for context, others are all-or-nothing
- Changes need to be reversible; will describe how it can be undone

Local Authority Records

A quick and simple way to make direct 1:1 changes

- Derived from existing LCSH records
- Added field to include rationale for the change
- Alma's Preferred Term Correction job automatically changes the subject headings
- Used for Illegal immigration, Sexual minorities, and Problem children



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Quickest approach we took was creating local authority records (AR).

- Simple process: derive a new local AR for preferred term from the existing LCSH authority record
- In Alma, creating derived ARs are saved in the same vocabulary, so saved in LCSH but local
- Good for those direct 1:1 changes as this is an all-or-nothing change
- Notes field added to include rationale; people know what the AR is for without extra documentation
- Original LCSH retained in alternative term field; important
    - Alma's preferred term correction job – runs nightly and automatically replaces terms
    - Uses LCSH in alternative term field and local AR being in LCSH vocab to connect the 2 terms
    - Makes original LCSH searchable; users get same results searching either term

  Undo change by reversing local AR (LCSH in main entry), let PTC job run, delete the local AR

  Alma automatically relinks after local AR is deleted

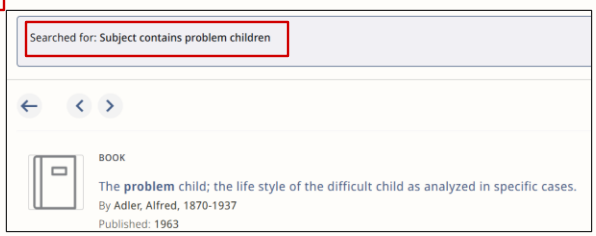
  Used for Ill immigration, sexual minorities, problem children

010	__ |a sh 85107104
035	__ |a (DLC) sh 85107104
035	__ |a (LIBRARY_OF_CONGRESS)98170919900000041
040	__ |a DLC |c DLC |d DLC |d ViU
150	__ |a Children with behavioral problems
450	__ |a Problem children |5 NbU
450	__ |a Difficult children
450	__ |a Maladjusted children
550	__ |w g |a Children
550	__ |a Behavior disorders in children
667	__ |a "Problem children" is a term that was used in educational and psychological literature to describe children with behavior issues due to emotional instability or social environment. The literature has shifted to focus on the behavior rather than the nature of the children, making this term outdated. Current headings found in relevant databases include "behavior problems" and "problem behavior." UNL Libraries considers "Children with behavioral problems" to be a more respectful and neutral term and that it maintains parity with the terminology currently found in the relevant psychological and educational literature databases.
670	__ |a Difficult children, there is no such thing, c2003: |b t.p. introd. (children demonstrating behavioral disorders are being classified as educationally difficult to manage)
680	__ |i Here are entered works on children with behavior difficulties due to emotional instability or social environment.

Local AR for Children w/ behavioral problems
Main entry (150) - preferred term
Alt term field (450) - LCSH
Notes field (667) - Rationale

Details

Title	The **problem** child; the life style of the difficult child as analyzed in specific cases.
Creator	Adler, Alfred, 1870-1937
Publisher	New York Capricorn Books
Creation Date	1963
Format	xvii, 172 p. 21 cm
Note	"The present volume was published in German in 1930, as one of the volumes on Die Technik der Individualpsychologie ... and bore the subtitle Die Seele des schwererziehbaren Schulkindes."
Subject	**Children with behavioral problems**
Series	A Capricorn giant original, 228
Source	Library Catalog



https://unl.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01UON_LINC/4occt9/alma991017618739706387

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Local AR impacted record in display
Local subject is linked
Record was found by searching LCSH Problem children

Normalization Rules

Some LCSH have multiple meanings or contexts that make a direct one-to-one change unsuitable.

- Normalization rules can change context-specific subject headings
- Used for the subject headings "Noncitizens" only when it appeared in records alongside "Illegal immigration"
- Rule is applied quarterly to catch newly added records

```
rule "Change 650.a Noncitizens to 650.a Undocumented immigrants when appearing with 650.a Illegal immigration"
when
    (exists "650.a.Noncitizens*") and (exists "650.a.Undocumented immigration*|Illegal immigration*")
then
    replaceContents "650.a.Noncitizens" with "Undocumented immigrants"
end
```


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Local ARs good for 1:1 changes, but not all LCSH can be changed 1:1
Multiple meaning or contexts that make them impossible to be replaced with a single new term
Example: Noncitizens: used to describe several immigration and citizenship scenarios (e.g. Roman law)
Inappropriate to use Undocumented in that case.
Normalization rules (NR) used for contextual changes (i.e. when it appears with Illegal immigration)
NRs are scripts that can be used to programmatically edit bibliographic metadata
That condition is written into NR (see screenshot)
Rules can be scheduled to run on a logical set of records including all records containing both LCSH – applied quarterly to catch new records
Similar to local ARs, easy to undo. Edit rule to perform opposite action and apply them to records



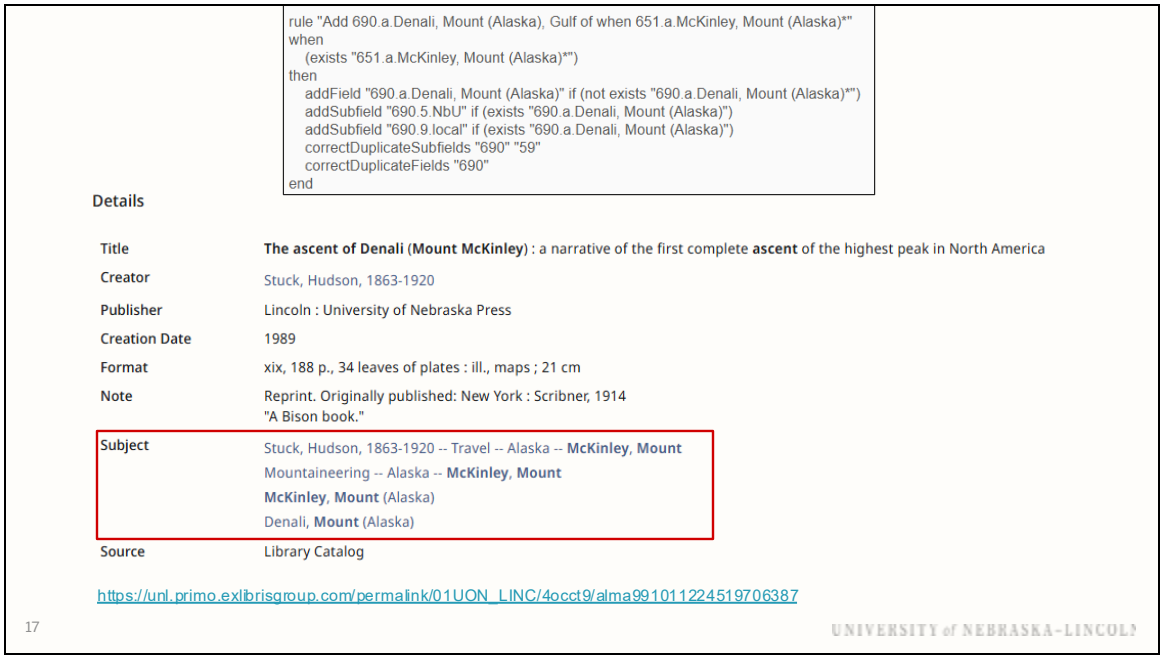
A record that has been affected NR in display
New subjects are linked
May be some discovery issues for users searching the LCSH because NR changes the metadata without a connection to original LCSH

Normalization Rules

In some cases, we deemed it appropriate to supplement LCSH rather than replace them.

- Normalization rules added our supplemental headings in records that had specific LCSH
- This approach was used for the LCSH "America, Gulf of" and "McKinley, Mount (Alaska)" to support discoverability
- Added subject term in a local subject field (690)

NRs also used for supplementing.
Supplementary approach only used for geographic headings – best for discoverability to have both names
Other name added as a local subject field



Top: part of NR adding the local subject field (690)
Bottom: record in display which has both names

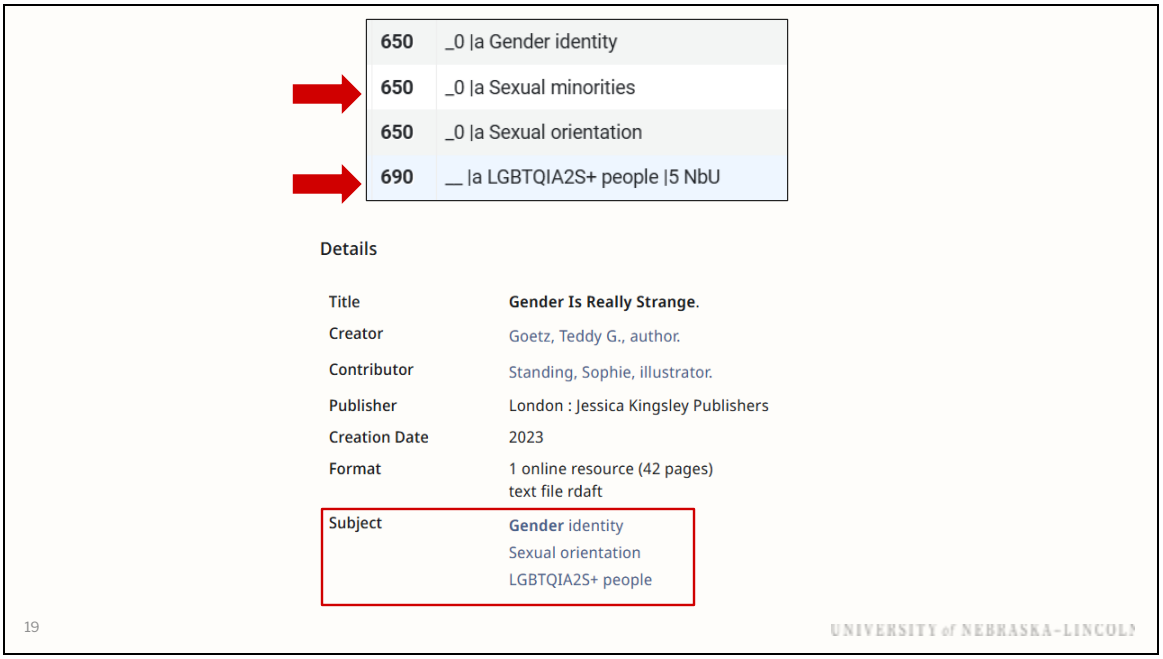
Challenges: Community Zone (CZ)

We are unable to change existing metadata in records sourced from the Alma CZ

- Normalization rules can supplement CZ records with preferred subject headings
- Subjects are added in a local subject field (690)
- LCSH are hidden from display using DEI exclude list in instances of direct 1:1 changes

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Challenges with Alma's complex environment: specifically with Community Zone (CZ) sourced records
CZ: a shared repository in Alma that contains electronic resource metadata and authority files that is accessible to all Alma users
Unable to edit existing metadata in CZ sourced records
NR used to supplement CZ records with local subject fields (690)
For 1:1 we hid LCSH from display using DEI exclude list – more about that in next slide



Top: subject headings in a record with both LCSH and replacement term
Bottom: affected record in display – no LCSH just replacement term

Challenges: CDI Records

The only tool capable of impacting Central Discovery Index (CDI) records is Alma's DEI exclude list

- The DEI exclude list can remove and replace subject terms and add annotations to subjects in display
- It is limited in function and is only useful for direct 1:1 changes in CDI records
- Using it will apply to all records, not just CDI

CDI, or Central Discovery Index: Ex Libris's centralized index of scholarly content, including journal articles, ebooks, and other electronic resources
We also cannot edit the metadata in these records
Only tool that affects them is DEI exclude list because it is a discovery tool
DEI exclude list allows you to create a list of words and phrases that can be removed or replaced in Subject fields
Functionality is pretty limited and we only found it to be useful for direct 1:1 changes
Ccannot limit the scope of the DEI exclude list to just CDI records

Results

LCSH	Repaired subject heading
~~Illegal immigration~~	Undocumented immigration
~~Problem children~~	Children with behavioral problems
~~Sexual minorities~~	LGBTQIA2S+ people
McKinley, Mount (Alaska)	Denali, Mount (Alaska)
America, Gulf of	Mexico, Gulf of

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- We have replaced Illegal immigration, Problem children, and Sexual minorities as well as nearly 100 variants with the terms Undocumented immigration, Children with behavioral problems, and LGBTQIA2S+ people
- In some contexts we have replaced Noncitizens with Undocumented immigrants
- We have supplemented the heading for Gulf of America and Mount McKinley with their former names.

Next Steps & Resources

Although the pilot project has finished, the work continues.

- A new group will convene to continue identifying problematic and replacement subject headings
- We are developing a submission form for users to let us know if they find a subject heading in need of reparative work
- We are maintaining a GitHub repository containing our normalization rules and workflows

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Pilot is finished but we are committed to maintaining a sustainable workflow for reparative metadata work whenever new subject headings are identified
Going forward – 3 items

- Draft charge for new group – will identify terms, do research, and communication, but technical work will remain with metadata librarians
- Developing a submission form for users and colleagues to submit subject headings they find in our catalog
- Maintaining a GitHub repository containnig NRs and other info about our workflows for other libraries to benefit from

Resources

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Resources listed here include both resources that we used to help design the workflows and implement the changes technically, as well as the research we used to support our rationale changing each subject heading.

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Thank you!





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